

AP PHOTO/JAE C. HONG



HE WAS PRESIDENTIAL BEFORE HE WAS ELECTED. THE DEMEANOUR WAS STATES-MANLIKE, A FINE BALANCE BETWEEN PRIVATE AMBITION AND PUBLIC DIGNITY.



THE OBAMAS WITH VICE-PRESIDENT ELECT JOE BIDEN AND HIS WIFE JILL BIDEN AT THE CHICAGO RALLY

Jakarta. The campaign began there.

It progressed through such Ivy League campuses like Columbia and Harvard, culminating in Chicago, where it was a career-shaping whirl of church (read the gospel according to Jeremiah Wright), community service and, inevitably, politics. In 1996 he won a seat in the Illinois state senate. Nine years later he would reach Capitol Hill. And along the way, he made his first million by writing two lyrical bestsellers (there were no ghosts) about himself. He had to tell his own story, and even at the age of 34, he thought it was a story worth telling. A story America should not miss. He was the classical African-American over-achiever. On the night of November 4, his life story became one with the equally inspiring story of the American

Dream. The campaign that began from the streets of Jakarta came to an end in Grant Park in Chicago. Remember, it was a campaign, unlike that of the Kennedys or the Bushes, unaided by the privilege of class and pedigree. Quite natural, Jesse Jackson could not control his tears when he was one of the 200,000 in the Park.

America is still popping the corks to celebrate the historic confluence of an exceptional biography and the destiny of an exceptional nation. And the Barry cocktails are going to stay for a while in the bar menus of D.C. So, the mood is: live out the dream and ask no questions. Soon, as the most powerful politician on earth, he will have to make hard choices at

home and beyond. With the Democrats controlling the Congress and the White House, is it going to be a dangerous turn to the left, as feared by the conservative America. "There is an old saying that politics in America is played between the 40 yard lines. What this means, for those unfamiliar with football, is that we're a centrist country, never straying very far to the left or the right in elections or national policies. This has been true for decades. It probably won't be after today's election," wrote *The Weekly Standard's* Fred Barnes in *The Wall Street Journal*, which, though, endorsed Obama. Will the spread-the-wealth social healer turn out to be a liberal radical? The fear is palpable despite the euphoria.

The Bush era may have marked